

BEFORE

The autocratic actions of China's First Emperor, Qin Shi Huang, alienated the population, and his successors were unable to quell the widespread rebellion that broke out against them.

QIN DYNASTY

Qin Shi Huang's son, the Second Emperor, fell under the influence of the eunuch Zhao Gao, who persuaded him to execute Li Si, his father's first minister, by having him cut in two in the market place at Xianyang. The Second Emperor was forced to commit suicide in 207 BCE and was succeeded by his son. By then rebellion had spread and the **Qin dynasty** << 126–27, which was to have lasted "ten thousand generations," ended.

THE FIRST HAN EMPEROR

Liu Bang, who came from a poor peasant family, rose to prominence as the leader of a rebel band. At first he supported Xiang Yu, an aristocrat who hoped to revive the feudal states. In 206 BCE Liu Bang captured **Xianyang**, the Qin capital, negotiated the surrender of the last Qin ruler, and announced the repeal of the severe **Qin penal code**. His treatment of the inhabitants earned him a reputation for fairness. When Xiang Yu arrived, the city was looted and the royal family killed. The rebel leaders quarreled, and for the next four years they campaigned against each other. Although Liu Bang's forces suffered defeats, he continued to gather allies, and in 202 BCE he won a decisive victory at Gaixia in modern Anhui.



HOW WE KNOW

COUNTESS OF DAI'S TOMB

In 1972 the tomb of the Countess of Dai, dated c. 168 BCE, was found at Mawangdui in present-day Hunan province. The grave offerings included silk garments, lacquer bowls for wine and food, and wooden figurines of her servants. The beautiful

painted banner draped over

her inner coffin is one of the earliest surviving examples of Chinese painting on silk. It depicts the route her soul would take on its quest for immortality—to

the magic island of Penglai and then to the gates of paradise. The tomb also contained silk manuscripts and a divination board, with markings similar to those found on bronze mirrors of the period.

PAINTED SILK BANNER

The Centralized State

The Han dynasty, founded by Liu Bang in 202 BCE, created a powerful centralized state with a highly efficient civil service that would serve as a model for future Chinese emperors over the next two millennia.

Liu Bang (see BEFORE) assumed the style of *huangdi* or sovereign emperor (see p.127), and used Han as the title of the new dynasty. He is usually known as Emperor Gaozu. During his reign, which lasted until 195 BCE, many of the features of the Chinese imperial system took shape.

Gaozu himself was the embodiment of the principle that a man of peasant origins but of outstanding virtue could become emperor. He began his reign by announcing an amnesty and measures to restore peace. In the west and in the area around the new capital that he established at Chang'an, he continued Qin practices, applying direct rule in the form of commanderies (districts ruled by a centrally appointed governor). But in the east and south he initially accepted the existence of ten kingdoms,

whose rulers professed allegiance to him, although he later replaced them with members of his own family. In the commanderies he rewarded senior officials, military leaders, and leaders of non-Chinese groups who had submitted to the Han, by conferring on them the rank of marquis. This title allowed them to raise taxes for the state, retaining part of the money for themselves.

Promotion on merit

Gaozu formalized the system of bureaucratic government introduced under the Qin. The emperor was assisted by three senior officials, who were in turn supported by nine ministers, each with a defined area of responsibility.

Gaozu was contemptuous of scholars, but he recognized the importance of the Confucian ideals (see p.131) of

education and public service. In 196 BCE he issued an edict on the recruitment of able persons to the imperial government. The sixth Han emperor, Wudi, took this process even further.

Writing brushes

The ink brush was invented before the Han period, but came into its own under the Han for keeping detailed records—first on silk and then on paper (see right).

